RE: Developing tool that efficiently provides an individual or trusted advisor the information and contacts they need to address issues with electricity (& water?) in Fairfax County (may narrow to specific neighborhoods if easier to develop for) - issues such as increase in rates, help with bills, etc.

Problem Statement

Fairfax County residents are facing a worsening utility affordability crisis, and the support systems meant to help them can be fragmented that can be challenging to navigate and even know where to get started.

Proposed Solution

An AI conversational tool (potentially accessible via WhatsApp), that lets residents ask plain-language questions about their electric bill and get accurate, personalized routing to the right program, application, or human contact. This tool will help residents know what programs and options are available to them as they continue to face increasing utility costs.

Potential Resident Questions

1. Rate & Bill Increase:
    a. Why did my bill go up? (base rate increase, fuel surcharge, seasonal usage, data center demand, etc.)
    b. The rates for electricity have increased recently, making it hard to make ends meet. What can I do?
    c. Utility usage and associated bill seem high (compared to prior housing/neighbors/other). Is there a leak? Poor energy efficiency? What can I do? (if own? If rent?)
    d. I cannot pay my electric bill (utility bill). What can I do?
        i. Power company rate increase
        ii. Loss of income
        iii. Single bill surprisingly large
    e. What is this charge on my bill? (rate riders, adjustment clauses, fees, etc.)
    f. My electric bill has gone up over the past few months, will my bill keep increasing?
2. Disconnection Notice:
    a. I got a disconnection notice, what do I do right now?
    b. Can i get on a payment plan for my electric bill?
    c. I have a medical condition that requires electricity, what can i do to stop my electricity from being cut off?
3. Assistance Programs:
    a. Are there any assistance programs that I qualify for?
    b. Are there state or federal assistance programs I can apply for?

    c. What is the Percentage of Income Payment Program and how do I apply?
    d. What is the LIHEAP Assistance program and how do I apply?
    e. What is the EnergyShare program?
4. Usage & Efficiency
    a. Why is my usage so high?
    b. How can I reduce my electricity use in my home?
    c. Are there rebates available for efficiency upgrades in my area?
    d. A company stopped by our house and offered to buy solar panels for the house and said we would benefit from reduced electric bills. Should we do it?
5. Logistics
    - How do I set up electricity/water in a new house or apartment? Transfer account to me?
    - We have lost power (or water quality) in our house. (or apartment). What should I do?

Answer Resources

Understand my bill	https://www.dominionenergy.com/yourbill
Why is my bill high	https://www.dominionenergy.com/virginia/save-energy/why-is-my-bill-high https://www.fairfaxtimes.com/articles/fairfax-residents-utility-bills-set-to-rise-in-2026/article_7875a665-c056-4396-aca8-c65cfdbdb06c.html
Rate increases/ riders	https://www.dominionenergy.com/virginia/rates-and-tariffs
Disconnection rules	https://law.lis.virginia.gov/admincode/title20/agency5/chapter330/section40/
Percentage of Income Payment Program (PIPP)	https://www.dss.virginia.gov/relief/pipp/
EnergyShare (Dominion Energy)	https://www.dominionenergy.com/energyshare-va?print=true
Low Income Energy Assistance Program (LIEAP)	https://www.liheap.org/
Bill disputes/ complaints	https://www.scc.virginia.gov/consumers/public-utility/utility-complaints/
Scam verification	Dominion: Protect yourself of scams/ Report a scammer

Report Outage	Dominion Energy: 1-866-366-4357 / Report Form / View Outage Map NOVEC: 1-703-335-0500 / Outage Center
Energy Efficiency	https://energy.virginia.gov/connect/energy-efficiency https://www.nbcwashington.com/news/consumer/how-to-lower-energy-bills-as-summer-approaches/3896488/
Solar panel program	https://www.fairfaxcounty.gov/environment-energy-coordination/going-solar https://www.fairfaxcounty.gov/environment-energy-coordination/two-programs-help-residents-go-solar https://switchtogether.com/en/solar/fairfaxcounty/home
Data centers	https://www.pcrehomes.com/blog/data-centers-fairfax-utility-bills/ https://annandaletoday.com/massive-energy-use-by-data-centers-could-lead-to-higher-electric-bills/ https://www.brookings.edu/articles/confronting-and-addressing-rising-energy-bills-linked-to-data-centers/
Community support	Solar United Neighbors (nonprofit)

Goals

1. Content stays accurate as rates, thresholds, and deadlines change
2. can identify which assistance program(s) they may qualify for
3. Urgent cases (disconnection noises) are triggered and routed to an organization or government office where they can speak with someone about their issue
4. The tool builds trust with vulnerable populations and makes it easier for them to navigate a complex system and leaves them with a better understanding of their options

Decision Trees

- Need to define questions and decision trees to answer questions
    - The rates for electricity have increased making it hard to make ends meet, what can I do?
        -
        - What assistance programs do I qualify for?
        - Do I qualify for the Percentage of Income Payment Program?
            - What is the Percentage of Income Payment Program?
                - Pay your reduced bill in full and on time each month
                - Each month, 1/12 of your old balance is forgiven
                - After 12 months of on-time payments, your past-due balance is gone
            - Do I qualify for the Percentage of Income Payment Program?
                - Are you a Dominion Energy or APCo/AEP customer?
                - What is your household income?
                - Do you have an active electrical account?
                - Do you have proof of income for the past 30 days?
                - Do you have a current electric bill?
                - Do you have SSN for all members of your household?
            - How do i stay enrolled in the program?
                - Re-verify your income each year
                - Report changes in income or household size
                - Stay current on monthly payments
                - Missing payments, making partial payments or failing to re-verify may cause removal from the PIPP
            - How do I apply for the PIPP
                - Option 1: Apply online through CommonHelp
                - Option 2: Submit a paper application to your Local Department of Social Services
            - What documents do i need to apply for the PIPP?
                - Proof of income for the last 30 days for all adults (18+) in the household
                - Current electric bill
                - SSN for all household members
        - Do i qualify for Dominion Energy's EnergyShare program?
            - What is EnergyShare?
                - Energy assistance for people who are having problem paying their energy bills.
                - Available year-round, regardless of income.
                - Program can also provide free home energy upgrades to help you use less energy
            - Do i qualify for EnergyShare?
                - You must live in Dominion Energy's service area
                - Must have received a disconnection notice

        - Need your service reconnected
        - Need help keeping your payment plan
        - Have received a budget billing removal notice
        - If you're 60 years of age or older, you may qualify for help more often
        - Military veterans and people with disabilities may qualify for an extra $500
            - To qualify you must be enrolled in an approved voucher program through one of the following organizations
                - Virginia Department of Veterans Services
                - Virginia Department of Aging and Rehabilitative Services' Center for Independent Living
- How does EnergyShare work?
    - Local agencies look at applications and decide who is eligible
    - If approved, the payment is sent directly to your energy company
- Is there a deadline to apply for EnergyShare
    - Help with Heating: October 1st - May 31st, Benefit Amount: up to $6000
    - Help with Cooling: June 1 - Sep. 30, Benefit Amount: up to $3000
- How do i apply for EnergyShare
    - You can find your local EnergyShare agency by calling 2-1-1 or visiting 211virginia.org
- What are EnergyShare's Free Home Energy Upgrades?
    - You may be able to get a free home energy assessment
    - A contractor will visit your home and recommend weatherization tips and ways to help you use less energy and lower your energy costs
- What energy upgrades are available through EnergyShare?
    - Upgrades may include LED light bulbs, low-flow showerheads and faucet aerators, attic/floor insulation, heat pump or air conditioner tune-ups, air and duct sealing, hot water take and pipe wrap insulation
- Do i qualify for EnergyShare upgrades?
    - Must be a Dominion Energy customer
    - Must have received bill payment help
- How do i apply for EnergyShare home upgrades?
    - Call 888-366-8280 and select the Income and Age Qualifying option